

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

Tense Hearing Puts Blanche In Tough Spot

Nominee Is Questioned on \$1.8 Billion Fund

This article is by **Glenn Thrush, Devlin Barrett, Michael Gold and Alan Feuer.**

WASHINGTON — The fate of Todd Blanche’s nomination as attorney general remained uncertain on Wednesday after a rocky confirmation hearing in which a Republican senator raised serious questions about his role in creating a \$1.8 billion fund for purported victims of Justice Department persecution.

The senator, John Cornyn of Texas, who was defeated by a Trump-backed opponent in a primary election, grilled Mr. Blanche about the fund and a related agreement granting President Trump and his family sweeping immunity from tax investigations.

Mr. Cornyn, a former judge, displayed text of the tax provision on a poster behind him and noted that Mr. Trump “has not agreed in writing” to nixing the fund.

After the hearing, he said he had not made up his mind. “I don’t have to make a decision now, so I’m not,” he said during a brief interview at the Capitol.

Even a single Republican “no” vote on the Judiciary Committee would block Mr. Blanche’s nomination from consideration by the full Senate, which could sink his confirmation. A second lame-duck Republican on the committee, Senator Thom Tillis of North Carolina, is also undecided but has said he is leaning toward voting “yes.”

Mr. Blanche’s confirmation is somewhat symbolic. He could serve in an acting capacity for the remainder of Mr. Trump’s term. But the referendum on Mr. Blanche is in a broader sense one on the president’s vision of the department as a projection of his power and extension of his will.

The unusual two-part deal approved by Mr. Blanche, intended to resolve Mr. Trump’s lawsuit demanding at least \$10 billion from the Internal Revenue Service over the leak of his tax returns, *Continued on Page A12*



KENNY HOLSTON/THE NEW YORK TIMES
Todd Blanche at a confirmation hearing for attorney general.

ICE Detained Aging Assassin. He Says He Can’t Be Deported.

By **JULIAN E. BARNES**

WASHINGTON — In 1976, Armando Fernandez Larios slipped into the United States to help plan an assassination.

He mapped the target’s routes to work, and collected details about his car, home and office in Washington. On Sept. 9, 1976, he passed the information to a Chilean intelligence agent in a bathroom at Kennedy International Airport in New York and then flew out of the country the same day to return to Chile.

Less than two weeks later, a car bomb exploded on the streets of Washington, killing Orlando Letelier, a former ambassador from Chile and a vocal critic of the country’s dictator, Gen. Augusto Pinochet. Mr. Letelier’s American col-

league, Ronni Karpen Moffitt, also died in the attack.

In 1987, Mr. Fernandez returned to the United States and confessed, at least in part, to his role. He spent five months in prison before U.S. officials helped secure his release. Since then, he has lived in Florida.

Then last October, Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents knocked on his door.

For years, the U.S. government regarded Mr. Fernandez as a helpful Cold War ally of sorts, even as its relationship with Chile deteriorated. But by last fall, he was viewed as a criminal who needed to be deported, underscoring how profoundly U.S. alliances and pri-

Continued on Page A17

Vote Exposes Rift on Israel By Democrats

By **ANNIE KARNI**

WASHINGTON — The House on Wednesday rejected a measure to eliminate U.S. aid to Israel, but almost half of Democrats supported the move, reflecting a rapid and dramatic shift within the party away from decades of unequivocal support for the Jewish state.

The measure, which sought to cut all \$3.3 billion in military and humanitarian aid to Israel from a foreign affairs spending bill, failed by a vote of 104 to 314, with 10 voting “present,” and all but one Republican, Representative Thomas Massie of Kentucky, a sponsor, voting no.

But more Democrats supported it than opposed it, including many who said they voted in favor despite their opposition to the cuts to humanitarian aid. It was the latest and starkest evidence of a major divide over backing Israel within the Democratic Party, which is grappling with a groundswell of hostility in its ranks toward Israel and its conduct of the war in Gaza.

Supporters said the measure was their only way to register their opposition to the actions of the Israeli government in Gaza, the West Bank and Lebanon, and their desire for a fundamental *Continued on Page A13*



CHRISTOPHER CAPOZZIELLO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
IN MAINE Flowers and candles for Joan Sebastian Guerrero of Colombia, who was fatally shot by an ICE agent on Monday. Page A16.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Trump Stymied by Foe Who Won’t Genuflect

By **PETER BAKER**

WASHINGTON — On the 136th day of his war against Iran, President Trump came up with a new plan. He would impose tolls on ships traversing the Strait of Hormuz in exchange for protecting them from Iranian forces.

But that was then. On Day 137, he had another new plan. No tolls after all.

Mr. Trump’s 180-degree reversal this week in the face of protests from his Arab allies who were not so excited about paying tolls reflected how adrift he seems to be in prosecuting his war against Iran. What was

President Struggles to Find Clear Strategy for Besting Iran

supposed to be a clean four-to-six-week operation is now in its messy 20th week. Improvisation and impulse are not working.

A president who has made flexing his power on the world stage a hallmark of his second term has found in Iran an opponent that so far will not bend to his will and a geopolitical conflict that cannot be won through

nasty social media posts or tariff threats. The memorandum of understanding that he brokered with Tehran last month to halt the fighting turns out to have been a memorandum of misunderstanding, and Mr. Trump now seems to have neither a clear military nor diplomatic strategy.

“He’s encountered a country that is not willing to play by his set of rules, which is you bend and kiss the ring and tell him how great he is and try to get whatever concession he’s willing to give,” said Vali Nasr, a professor at the Johns Hopkins University School of Advanced Interna-

Continued on Page A5



REBECCA BLACKWELL/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Another Masterpiece for Messi

Argentina stunned England, 2-1, with a pair of assists from Lionel Messi. Coverage at [nytimes.com](#).

Red or Blue? In This Town You Must Pledge Allegiance to a Bull.

By **ANA IONOVA**

PARINTINS, Brazil — The rift was hard to miss.

At dingy curbside bars, patrons dressed in red sat in red plastic chairs and guzzled red cans of beer. Their rivals, clad in blue, leaned into blue plastic chairs and downed blue cans of beer.

Three-wheeled rickshaws

zipped by, as riders bounced on benches tinted ruby red or royal blue. Banks and shops and crosswalks were also painted — one half red, the other blue.

Here, in the small Brazilian city of Parintins, staying neutral isn’t an option. “If you’re born here, you’re either red or you’re blue,” said Kellen Pinto, 48, whose family has lived here for generations. “You have to choose.”

BRAZIL DISPATCH

This is no rivalry over soccer or politics though. In this city of 100,000 people, perched on an island in the Amazon River, something else is driving a wedge: fierce allegiances to two rival bull mascots, represented by the colors blue and red.

The red bull is known as the bull of the people. The blue bull is

THE WEATHER

Today, hazy sun and clouds, reduced air quality from smoke, hot, less humid, high 92. Tonight, poor air quality, low 72. Tomorrow, some sun, high 88. Weather map, Page B8.

TRUMP DEMANDS ICE RESTART USE OF TRAFFIC STOPS

DEPORTATION EFFORTS

Push to Reverse a Pause Put in Place After 2 Fatal Shootings

By **MADELEINE NGO and ZOLAN KANNO-YOUNGS**

WASHINGTON — President Trump on Wednesday demanded that Immigration and Customs Enforcement officers continue to stop vehicles as they seek to detain people in the country without legal status, despite two fatal shootings that led to a temporary halt to the practice just a day before.

Officials with the Department of Homeland Security did not immediately say whether they were resuming the traffic stops, which they had largely halted after ICE agents shot and killed one person in Houston and another in Biddeford, Maine, in the span of one week.

In a social media post on Wednesday, Mr. Trump defended the traffic stops and urged ICE to “go back and do your very important job.”

“We CANNOT give up one of I.C.E.’s most important and effective Crime Fighting tools, THE TRAFFIC STOP!” Mr. Trump wrote. “Once we do, we are playing right into the criminal’s hands.”

Rapid shifts in policy are a recurring pattern as the Trump administration has sought to achieve the president’s goal of mass deportations. As the government’s aggressive tactics have drawn intense backlash, homeland security officials have scaled back the most visible aspects of their crackdown — only to feel the pressure to ratchet up arrests again as the president’s hard-line supporters demand that he not back away from his pledge.

“They are caught between the MAGA constituents who want mass deportation and the videos, court decisions, public opinion, on the use of force,” said Gil Kerlikowske, a former commissioner of Customs and Border Protection during the Obama administration.

On Wednesday, Markwayne Mullin, the homeland security secretary, did not directly say whether the agency was once again going to conduct vehicle stops. But he said in a statement that the department’s top goal was to keep officers safe and that “illegal aliens will be arrested and deported wherever they are.”

Before the president’s directive on traffic stops, Tom Homan, the White House border czar, tried to downplay the potential impact of the pause in an interview with Fox News on Tuesday, saying it was a temporary measure to “make sure we’re doing the right thing.”

However, many arrests occur after ICE officers pull over people in their cars, and the pause threatens to hamper the agency’s ability to increase arrests.

The recent shootings, and Mr. Trump’s push to keep up deportations, have created a political challenge for Republicans in tough re-

Continued on Page A16



INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Migrants Stuck in the Middle

As India drives out Bangladeshi immigrants, border standoffs leave people with no safe place to turn. *PAGE A4*

Terror Groups’ A.I. Edge

Chatbots are not just a propaganda tool, but also aid bomb construction and attack planning, research finds. *PAGE A9*

NATIONAL A11-18

Debate Over Age in Congress

The death of Senator Lindsey Graham has renewed criticism of a system that rewards seniority and tenure. *PAGE A14*

Plea for Carriage Ban

The family of a teenager killed by a runaway horse asked lawmakers to end the 167-year-old industry. *PAGE A18*

SPORTS B7-11

Spith Relives a Daring Drop

He won the 2017 British Open after escaping trouble by moving his ball all the way back to the driving range at Royal Birkdale, this week’s host. *PAGE B7*



BUSINESS B1-6

China’s Economy Slows

Growth of 4.3 percent in the second quarter was down from the first quarter and fell short of expectations. *PAGE B1*

Social Security in Transition

The agency is hiring workers and improving technology after the departure of about 7,800 staff members. *PAGE B1*

ARTS C1-6

Bong Exhibition Snuffed Out

A pioneering display of glass cannabis pipes scheduled at the Toledo Museum of Art was canceled, prompting speculation about why. *PAGE C1*

OBITUARIES A19, 22

He Skewed the Powerful

With an impious eye for wickedness in high places, Pat Oliphant became one of the nation’s best-known political cartoonists. He was 90. *PAGE A22*

OPINION A20-21

The Editorial Board

PAGE A20



THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

Return to the Sandlot

Backyard Baseball, a popular 1990s video game, had long been off the market. But a second-grade teacher, Lindsay Barnett, was determined. *PAGE D1*



0 354613 9